

Figure 3.7 *Bamiyan: north cliff, eastern end, with 35-m Buddha (fourth–fifth century), distant view. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

with the inner workings of a new elite continuing their seasonal transhumance. This urban court model, then, should be considered an even greater *abstraction* – rather than falsification – of the *locus* of power particularly in the case of elites from obscure, nomadic or transhumant origins.[34] With the increasingly refined archaeological work underway on empires emerging from nomadic confederacies, the juxtaposition of textual descriptions and archaeological finds is both increasingly imperative and, thankfully, possible.

Bamiyan

The UNESCO world heritage site of Bamiyan (Figure 3.7) looms large in the contemporary imagination. It is hard to think of Afghanistan or Buddhism without evoking Bamiyan – the mind's eye of the modern